

Abstract:

This piece will progress through four distinct categories. It will begin by describing the utility and context behind a potential feminist compass. The paper will then move to a description of the feminist understanding of masculinity – defined by C.J. Pascoe – which provides the framework within the proposed graph. That description will naturally require a brief overview of key categories within essentialism, coupled with a specific case study of a political movement (Trans Exclusionary Radical Feminists). Following this overview, the discussion will shift toward using the potential tool to map a cloud of talking points in a contemporary feminist debate.

While this idea will be alluded to throughout this piece, it is essential to recognize that neither masculinity nor femininity can be neatly defined. Despite being the inspiration for this inquiry, the complexity simultaneously hinders linguistic clarity in academic discussion. The primary goal of this paper is to be as clear as possible; some terms, however, will have to remain provisionally underdefined. Masculinity and femininity are the two main examples: both will be referred to as they are commonly understood. Additionally, ‘essentialists’ and ‘anti-essentialists’ will be referred to broadly and qualified when necessary. There is neither the space nor the intellectual scope to uncover all the nuances of gender identity in a piece on mapping feminist discourse. Thus, these provisional definitions will have to suffice.

Alistair Norfleet

Professor Conny Knieling

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What is a Feminist?: Understanding the Social Context of Feminist Terminology

Men who hate women are misogynists; women and non-men who hate men are misandrists. These terms, while effective in describing a simple dichotomous dynamic based on hate, do not represent reality; gender dynamics are far more complex than this duality. In modern feminism, the ‘woman question’ – building on older essentialist debates – continues to complicate progress. The nuances of trans-identities, gender performativity, and political positioning, all aspects of the modern feminist debate, require qualifiers to the standard definitions of gendered relationships. Men who hate men that hate women cannot be referred to as misandrists or misogynists. These two terms are equally useless for women who hate women that hate men. There must be, then, a better way to describe the relationships between gender, sex, and power.

Second and third-wave feminists introduced the idea of ‘gender performativity’, proposing that gender is an active process, rather than a fixed identity. On their own, people could perform gender just as they might ‘perform’ other identities, such as nicknames or professions. The underlying principle, then, is the use of implicit social controls of respect to enforce those identities. From the third-wave feminists onwards, identity became inextricably tied to notions of power, which has significantly affected modern politics. If advocates of gender

performativity are correct, it becomes markedly harder to establish any form of class identity. Regardless of its feasibility, it is unknown whether or not such class identity is necessary.

What is necessary, however, is a map. Though Simone de Beauvoir once noted the problems of defining oneself based on another, any well-reasoned debate requires knowing an opponent's agenda. Without solid boundaries that enshrine the logical conclusion of feminist theory, even authorities on the subject could inadvertently be speaking in different dialects.

In modern feminist discourse, it is the responsibility of current academics to avoid the same mistakes as those who came before; tying identity and politics, however, seems unavoidable as of the time of writing. The second feminists enshrined the personal into the political, which proves that identity – despite its relevance – can function as a talking point in politics. Thus, just as political thought can be provisionally graphed, so too can modern feminist positions.

Internalized Gender Dysphoria

C.J. Pascoe illustrated the fallacious and often violent realities of masculine hegemony in her book, *Dude, You're a Fag: Masculinity, Sexuality, and Power in High School*. Studying students in an American high school, Pascoe outlined the developmental effects of patriarchy on gender dynamics. Overall, she argued that those who benefit from patriarchy fall into four categories: hegemonic, complicit, subordinated, and marginalized masculinity.

Hegemonic masculinity primarily refers to white, wealthy, heterosexual, and cisgender men. Pascoe defines hegemonic masculinity as, “the type of gender practice that, in a given space and time, supports gender inequality, is at the top of this hierarchy”(Pascoe 7). They are the colonizers of young gendered society; ascribing to supposedly ‘advantageous’ qualities permits this group to use insults to silence dissent. Comparable to fascists, they leverage their pre-existing status, using their ‘purity’ as a fallacious justification to create a homogeneous and prejudicial society. Similarly, the complicit possess the most commonly accepted ‘masculine’ traits, coupled with a few external qualifiers that diminish their status. According to Pascoe: “Complicit masculinity describes men who benefit from hegemonic masculinity but do not enact it”(Pascoe 7). Hierarchical structures such as this require complacency from privileged members in advantageous positions. In a highly individualized society, hierarchies logically align with the personal interests of the oppressors. Additionally, the dissonance that the complacent experience in inaction rarely outcompetes a commitment to the status quo. This dynamic, however, does not end with them; violence inevitably begets more violence, and the subordinates are a symptom of it.

Subordinated masculinity involves men who noticeably deviate from certain dominant aspects of their gender. According to Pascoe: “describes men who are oppressed by definitions of

hegemonic masculinity”(Pascoe 7). Gay men, notably, do not follow the standard of heteronormativity. Furthermore, both trans-men and women have connections to masculinity but no ‘satisfactory’ claim to ‘purity.’ Since they do not fit the standard, they cling to what remains. Pascoe often noted a corollary relationship between the level of oppression and the emphasis on traditional ideals. Those subordinated by their identity may over-emphasize certain aspects of themselves to code-switch. This is a form of self-defense, though as Hannah Arendt wrote in *The Origins of Totalitarianism*: “What convinces masses are not facts, and not even invented facts, but only the consistency of the system of which they are presumably part” (Arendt 371). Homeostasis is a universal goal of all living organisms, and patriarchy uses that to subordinate young people into submission. Material conditions, then, are the driving force behind the need to defend oneself.

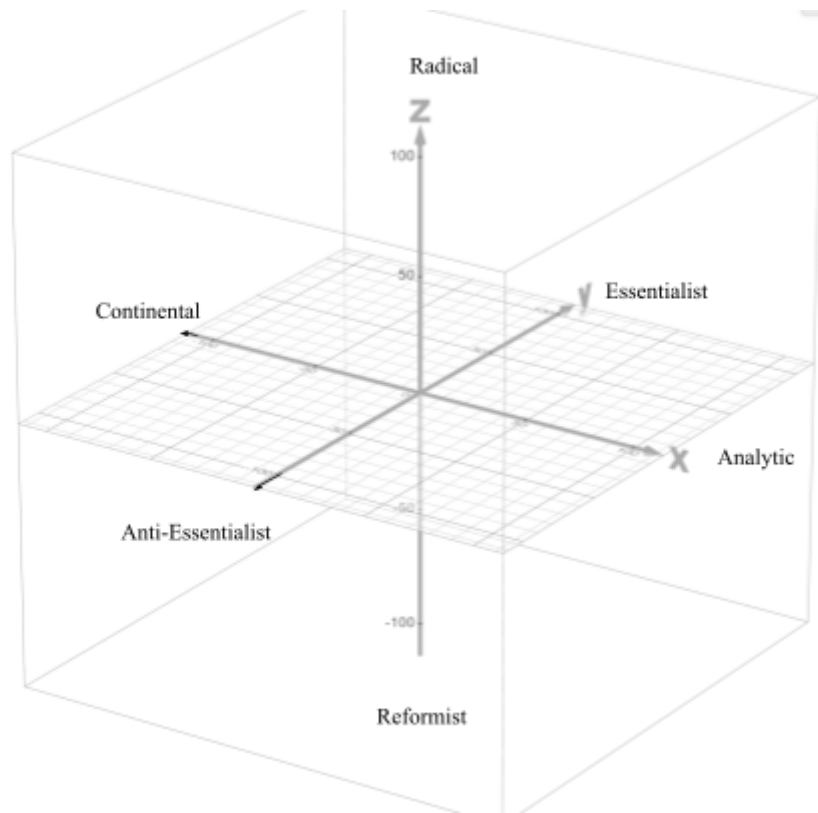
The marginalized arguably require a higher emphasis on traditional masculinity to defend themselves. Those with ‘marginalized masculinity’ possess a highly advantageous gender status but no privilege in regard to race or class. Pascoe defines marginalized masculinity as: “men who may be positioned powerfully in terms of gender but not in terms of class or race”(Pascoe 7). This tier is less of an obstacle for the ‘woman question,’ however, as the compass need not address class-based ends. These four spheres of masculinity present potentially valid axes for a feminist compass. Men who are either hegemonically or complicitly masculine require a linguistic basis to oppress others; gendered language, therefore, underlines their claim to ‘superiority.’ Those who genuinely believe they deserve their status would align closer with continental philosophy, which operates on Mainland-European philosophical understandings of the world. This tradition, though immensely broad, inadvertently satisfies the ends of dominant masculinity through its use of gendered language. On one end would be the continental, with the

other representing the analytic. Analytic philosophy, then, is the natural opposite because it questions whether commonly used terms are valid despite their wide acceptance and use. This paper mainly relates graphing feminist philosophy of language; thus, the spectrum will primarily pertain to continental and analytical perspectives on linguistic philosophy.

Those with ‘subordinated masculinity’ are affected by the relative validity of their respective claims to masculinity. This dissonance characterizes the problem of conflating identity with political feminist ends. The central debate over the ‘woman question’ is, put simply, between essentialists and anti-essentialists. They debate relative claims to femininity, and though that relationship functions differently than its oppressive counterpart, the dynamic of purity remains similar. While unsatisfactory as a mere dichotomy, they are much more effective as two ends of a spectrum. These two positions, therefore, become the y-axis of the feminist compass. People who fall under ‘marginalized masculinity’ present an entirely different problem and therefore require any sufficient compass to include a third axis. In a political context, ‘reactionary’ and ‘radical’ are qualifiers that denote intent. Reactionary ideologues emerge in response to temporary social disruption. These groups often rely more on personal experience or current events in establishing their platform. Radicals, conversely, are characterized by their adherence to personally held ideals. Though their tactics may change with current events, their goals remain constant. This relationship defines the third axis. Some participants in the gender debate have the ability to prioritize consistency alongside reform. Others, however, have no such privilege. The provisional z-axis, accordingly, would be between reformists and radicals.

The Feminist Cube

The final compass contains eight ideological cubes in a three dimensional diagram. The continental-reformists, continental-radicals, analytical-reformists, and analytical-radicals appear on both sides of the essentialist spectrum. These eight categories provide a satisfactory framework to consistently characterize the inconsistent nature of identity-ideology.



A Brief Aside on Bioessentialism

For essentialists, womanhood is often conflated with biology, forming what is known as ‘bio-essentialism.’ A bio-essentialist approach attaches womanhood to the possession of two X chromosomes, specific hormonal profiles, or sex assigned at birth. This perspective definitionally excludes transgender individuals from claiming femininity and, by extension, from inclusion in a gender-based coalition. It is important to note, however, that transgender women can achieve vitals identical to people assigned female at birth. According to the NIH: “After 4 months of hormone therapy, transwomen have Hgb/HCT levels equivalent to those of cisgender women” (Harper). Regardless of gender fluidity, specific hormone levels are not a satisfactory condition for assigning gender identity. Despite this, sex-specific vitals are often used as a concrete and quantifiable indicator of gender. There is no clear hormonal cutoff for gender; men, for instance, are often prescribed testosterone for a deficiency yet retain their male identity. These patients are considered male regardless of their condition, and the same standard ought to apply to women. Furthermore, the existence of infertile individuals is equally damaging to bio-essentialist arguments. Attaching gender to biological traits inevitably fails when confronted with biological variance – a natural feature of any living population. Homogeneity, therefore, is the logical endpoint of bio-essentialist rhetoric and is biologically disadvantageous for any species. The incestuous progression of essentialist rhetoric is ultimately futile for navigating feminism, though it remains crucial to understand the underlying goals of such movements.

TERF War

Trans-Exclusive Radical Feminists, or ‘TERFs’, are misandrists in disguise. Their purported belief in bio-essentialism serves as a talking point toward a broader agenda of alienating men. Some even refer to the transgender female community as “‘TIMs’ [Trans Identified Males]”(Meisler). This, naturally, causes issues when referring to trans-women, who are not men, but in fact, women. J.K. Rowling stands out as a notable TERF; at one point, in response to trans-activism, “argued against throwing ‘open the doors of bathrooms and changing rooms to any man who believes or feels he's a woman’” (Rowling).

TERFs fit neatly in the model. In fact, two extremes are already satisfied. TERFs, by definition, are ideologically essentialist and radical; therefore, they personally hold the belief that there is a unifying essential trait in ‘womanhood’. TERFs have defended the concept of traditional gender purity, much to the chagrin of the broader feminist movement. As a result of their exclusivity, transgender individuals may experience the same oppressive conditions of womanhood, only to find themselves excluded from a fractured coalition. Given their deeply held beliefs, TERFs are ironically constrained to the radical and essentialist ends of the spectrum. Consequently, major ideological fluctuations within this group will primarily be recognized along the x-axis, or the continental-analytic spectrum.

A Close Shave

Another contentious debate in modern feminism: to shave, or not to shave – that is the question. Some feminists argue that shaving is anti-feminist, as it is primarily done to satisfy patriarchal expectations of women. According to Kate Cohen of The Washington Post: “Every choice to conform to sexist social norms makes it harder for other women to choose otherwise. Every woman who has plastic surgery or Botox or gets her hair dyed or, yes, changes her name makes it harder for other women not to”(Cohen). The logical conclusion of this argument is that any action taken by a woman to satisfy patriarchal expectations must be anti-feminist. Logic aside, this argument is a major point of contention in modern feminism.

Considering the recency of this debate, it is also essential to qualify that this issue is not necessarily a representative sample of modern feminist discourse. The goal of the tool is to be able to create a form of consistency to map out the inconsistent nature of feminist thought. Thus, any topic relating to feminism may suffice, but a more prevalent and recent example lends more validity to a model that initially focuses on 20th century philosophy. Furthermore, while historical context inevitably clouds ideas from era to era, this tool is focused on pure ideology rather than circumstance. In that vein, philosophers will be analyzed broadly to fit into categories, just as historians have fit them into eras.

An individual with a firm belief in maintaining body hair may occupy various positions across the three axes. While body and head hair growth vary significantly by sex, this variance is largely influenced by hormones. A trans-woman, for example, may confound a TERF by presenting with virtually identical hair growth patterns. Body hair purity would therefore force an essentialist to question the extent to which patriarchy defines ‘female’ hair. In fact, under a

hair-purist worldview, a trans woman who meets these hair standards may be considered a better feminist for it, by virtue of her active pursuit of gender solidarity with women.

This circumstance is a microcosm of the larger debate – one that cannot be satisfactorily simplified without losing important nuance. The example above, however, reveals the complexity inherent in defining womanhood. Similar to its political counterpart, this feminist compass accommodates extensive personal variance in ideology.

Time to Consort the Cube

Essentialist-Continental-Reformists: An essentialist-continental-reformist feminist might advocate for feminine shaving through an appeal to Elizabeth Cady Stanton. Stanton, a notable essentialist, believed inherent traits bound women to care work; she simultaneously used this argument to advocate for equal-opportunity reforms. As an example, Stanton is quoted saying: “as a woman, an equal factor in civilization, her rights and duties are still the same – individual happiness and development”(Stanton). Her proposed reforms included equal access to education, property rights, employment, liberal divorce laws, and child custody rights. While her beliefs undoubtedly helped women gain access to important social infrastructure, she also held that reform was the solution to the abortion debate. Her vocal opposition to legal abortion was founded on the ideology that implicit social controls could reform the system. These implicit controls included religious reform, wider adoption of humanizing rhetoric for women, and the dissolution of the social belief that children were property. It is clear, then, that Stanton was not opposed to government intervention regarding female bodies. While her specific position on the shave debate is difficult to propose without conjecture, the basic ideals of bodily autonomy – or lack thereof – hold.

An essentialist-continental-reformist, then, may support one of the recent moves, at the time of writing, by Secretary of the Army Pete Hegseth: the Secretary has instituted facial hair standards for soldiers that apply regardless of gender. At time of writing, The Hill reports on the new policy which requires soldiers, “to be clean shaven and neat in presentation” (Fortinsky). This act was sparked by the belief that certain soldiers are not meeting visual standards and must comply with social expectations to maintain their positions. This is an example of this ideology in action, and while Hegseth’s personal feminist position is tentative, the logical conclusion of essentialist-continental-reformist argumentation aligns with such measures.

Essentialist-Continental-Radicals: An essentialist-continental-radical feminist might advocate using the philosophy of Mary Wollstonecraft. Wollstonecraft notably argued that women and men are identical in their capacity for reason and virtue. This belief permeated all aspects of her work, solidifying her as a proponent of radical and fundamental change to the social recognition of women. While Wollstonecraft argued for this core equality, she also peppered her work with the idea that women had inherent ties to motherhood. She argued, in *A Vindication of Rights of Woman*, “The conclusion which I wish to draw is obvious; make women rational creatures, and free citizens, and they will quickly become good wives, and mothers”(Wollstonecraft 184). In this respect, Wollstonecraft aligns with a modern essentialist platform, though she was considered anti-essentialist in her own time due to her focus on socially conditioned femininity. Considering the historical context, this advocacy likely stemmed from her emphasis on equal access to education, which places her in a more moderate position within the essentialist spectrum. Accordingly, while equally difficult to predict without some assumptions, her emphasis on social conditioning directly reflects a fear of outside manipulation. Agency, then, is the key value that holds from this perspective in context.

In a modern context, the archetype of the ‘tradwife,’ or traditional wife, is highly prevalent in conservative rhetoric. According to Michael Tesler, “many more conservatives today think women should ‘return to their traditional gender roles’ than they did two years ago”(Tesler). While modern conservatives often demonize feminism in their rhetoric, their underlying gender arguments mirror first-wave feminist thought when viewed historically. Within the shaving debate, traditional wives may frame shaving as a natural responsibility of femininity and motherhood. This position would be supported by a history of gendered philosophy and rooted in a deep belief in the role of traditional femininity within the home – a role largely structured by patriarchal expectations.

Essentialist-Analytical-Reformists: An essentialist-analytical-reformist feminist might appeal to the reasoning of Arthur Schopenhauer, who challenged ‘pure reason’ through his concept of a universal will. As a foundational analytic philosopher, Schopenhauer often argued that argumentation was more a dialectical battle than a purely logical one. This focus on persuasion underpinned his concept of a universal ‘will to live,’ which he used to characterize all living beings. Regarding the validity of pure reason, Schopenhauer argues: “It is true we see the individual come into being and pass away; but the individual is only phenomenal, exists only for the knowledge which is bound to the principle of sufficient reason, to the *principio individuationis*”(Schopenhauer). This reasoning could theoretically support feminist ends by dismantling the validity of gendered language. Despite this potential, he stated in *Studies in Pessimism*: “The case is not altered by particular and partial exceptions; taken as a whole, women are, and remain, thorough-going Philistines, and quite incurable”(Schopenhauer). Thus, Schopenhauer simultaneously undermines pure reason through an analytic approach, advocates

for a reform to the collective understanding of reason, and generalizes women into an essentialist category.

In a modern context, an argument explicitly based on Schopenhauer's misogyny falls outside the Overton Window, or socially accepted range, of political discourse; accordingly, only religious fundamentalists might openly support such a view. If, however, one adapts his concept of a pure “will to live” to argue for essentialist-analytical-reformist ends, they could posit that a woman’s inherent will to thrive naturally constrains her to the household. With socially enforced expectations that women are bound to the home, the underlying principle in this historical context is deeply conservative. Consequently, within this model, patriarchal expectations – such as shaving – could be framed as inherent duties of the domestic sphere. This would require little direct governmental intervention, relying instead on more forceful conditioning of gender roles from a young age. If these conditions are met, a platform derived from Schopenhauer's philosophy fits the proposed model.

Essentialist-Analytical-Radicals: Wittgenstein is an icon of analytical philosophy. While he acknowledged in his work that some of his ideas were not original, he pioneered the idea that language merely represented a logical form of reality, rather than reality itself. Most of Wittgenstein’s arguments stem from a fundamental belief that philosophical problems are the result of linguistic misunderstandings. He contended that the expression of ideas is intrinsically limited by language, as one must always fit ideas into a predetermined grammatical structure and a finite vocabulary. According to Wittgenstein, these constraints are inherent to language itself, thus binding any speaker and restricting free expression. His philosophy clearly serves analytical-radical ends, presenting a worldview that demands a complete reinterpretation of language while dismissing logical positivism. In modern feminism, his work is often cited to

undermine the validity of linguistically structured oppression, particularly gendered language. Despite this, Wittgenstein personally ascribed to essentialist views of women. This was evident in his lectures, where he was once quoted saying: “Thank God we’ve got rid of the women!”(Laugier) – to G.E.M. Anscombe. His exception is crucial in qualifying his essentialism.

Unlike Schopenhauer, Wittgenstein provisionally accepted female agency on the condition of adopting masculine traits. “As is well known, Wittgenstein solved this ‘contradiction’ by affectionately addressing Anscombe as ‘old man’, thus making her an ‘honorary male’”(Elliot). While progressive in his ability to separate intellectual capacity from womanhood, he rhetorically referred to women as a monolithic class and, to some degree, believed in class-based intellectual inequality. For Wittgenstein, exceptions were made based on masculine behavior, as seen with Anscombe. He diverges in this sense from bio-essentialists, operating instead on an underlying assumption of feminine inferiority that could be temporarily suspended by a masculine performance. While in the historical context, cross-dressing may not naturally indicate transness or gender performativity, Wittgenstein actively wanted Anscombe to act like a man. Therefore, his actions imply a personal disposition towards cross-dressing. This could determine traits about the philosopher. Instead, it is more prudent to recognize its implications on his lasting ideology; performativity and agency, namely, stand out. Since ideals of gender performativity and agency oppose conditioned grooming, cognitive dissonance and appeals against oneself characterize his position. On the proposed model, he would fit within the essentialist-analytical-radical category, despite his enduring relevance to anti-essentialist argumentation.

Anti-Essentialist-Continental-Reformists: Simone de Beauvoir was instrumental in bringing the distinction between sex and gender to academic prominence. Her analysis of othering in *The Second Sex* has had a lasting impact on modern understandings of gender. She argued that a fixed idea or definition of ‘woman’ could not exist, thus providing a definitive response to the ‘woman question.’ In her argument, Beauvoir emphasized gender fluidity by positing that social conditioning creates ‘femininity.’ According to Beauvoir: “One is not born, but becomes a woman”(Beauvoir 14). Her ideas align with the analytical philosophical skepticism of pure reason, particularly regarding the universal validity of gendered language. Despite this alignment, her reasoning stemmed from a starkly different motivation. As an existentialist philosopher, she believed that existence precedes essence; if this is true, then one's use of personal agency determines their essence. With no solid definition of ‘woman,’ Beauvoir gave minimal credence to prescribed gender roles, instead alluding to gender performativity at the individual level. Within a historical context, and especially within Europe, a consumerist trend like shaving was less likely to appear during her life. Limited by both relative geography and historical context, the most stable ideals prioritize personal agency, which rejects socially assigned meaning. Socially assigned meaning, then, would provide little incentive to someone of her position. Accordingly, Beauvoir can be classified as an anti-essentialist-continental-reformist, based on her belief in gender fluidity, her existentialist foundations, and her advocacy for reforming the language of ‘othering.’

Anti-Essentialist-Continental-Radicals: Judith Butler, building directly upon the work of Beauvoir, explicitly advocated for ‘gender performativity’ rather than merely alluding to it. This explicit stance is key to her radical position. Butler firmly maintained that gender is a performative act, akin to other self-determined identities, which society inadequately forces into

binary categories like masculine and feminine. Her radical approach centered on abolishing binary understandings of gender, particularly any notion of a 'fixed' gender identity: "In an important sense, gender is not traceable to a definable origin because it is itself an originating activity incessantly taking place"(Butler 507). Butler argued that individuals could – and sometimes should – 'parody' gender by deliberately subverting socially constructed norms. For example, a woman might stop shaving as an act of parody. In terms of philosophical alignment, her strong ties to existentialism via Beauvoir are evident in her emphasis on self-determination. While historical tension is much more prevalent in older philosophers, Butler's emphasis on subverting gender norms directly supports those who argue that feminists ought not shave. Rather than supporting rigid categories, Butler placed significant emphasis on the individual's pursuit of gender identity, prioritizing existence over essence.

Anti-Essentialist-Analytical-Reformists: Donna Haraway used her concept of 'situated knowledges' to propose a reformulation of objectivity. While changing the meaning of objectivity may seem radical, Haraway explicitly argues against radical change: "The further I get in describing the radical social constructionist program and a particular version of postmodernism, coupled with the acid tools of critical discourse in the human sciences, the more nervous I get" (Haraway 577). Rather than advocating for complete systemic upheaval, her approach centers on "a search for translation, convertibility, mobility of meanings, and universality – which I call reductionism only when one language (guess whose?) must be enforced as the standard for all the translations and conversions" (Haraway 580). Her emphasis on 'situated knowledges' – which simultaneously bolsters the validity of a revised objectivity while pursuing egalitarian feminist ends – is inherently reformist. Here, she does not advocate for systemic overthrow; instead, she suggests that qualifying objectivity and recognizing bias are

pathways to strengthening the sciences. Haraway's approach used analytical reasoning, with little personal belief in essentialism or any linguistic objectivity, and met the conditions to be an anti-essentialist-analytical reformist. This position would give little credence to any definition of a universal woman. Accordingly, her line of logic eventually ends in the dismantling of rigid gender roles on the basis that no objective position can exist. Her analytical reformist platform is characterized by timeless themes of an apprehensive acceptance of the status quo, holding out for change. In that respect, her position may be complicit to patriarchal roles.

Anti-Essentialist-Analytical-Radicals: Gayatri Spivak challenged colonial control in her seminal piece, *Can the Subaltern Speak?* Through an analytical lens, she interrogated the assumption that victims of colonial or systemic oppression inherently possess the ability to organize against their oppressors. In her work, she argued that colonizers – or oppressors broadly – control which language is taught, spoken, and disseminated. Spivak posits: “The necessarily dislocated machine of history moves because ‘the identity of the interests’ of these proprietors ‘fails to produce a feeling of community, national links, or a political organization’”(Spivak 72). Because the spread of revolutionary ideas is necessary for revolution, oppressors can preemptively silence dissent by controlling this informational supply line. Furthermore, in colonial contexts, forcing indigenous populations to speak the language of their oppressor fundamentally constrains their capacity for self-expression. While her work primarily characterizes colonial systems, she applies the same analytical framework to feminist ends. Regarding women, her argument parallels her analysis of colonial oppression. The patriarchy, in this case, uses gendered language to ‘other’ women, thereby oppressing them and forcing the oppressed to adopt their oppressor’s linguistic framework. As a vehement critic of gendered language and any form of hegemonic linguistic control, Spivak is positioned firmly as an

anti-essentialist. Even considering her tactical endorsement of 'strategic essentialism,' her qualification of it as a conditional necessity implies that anti-essentialism remains the normative stance. Her arguments against pure logic and the objectivity of language cement her as an analytic feminist. Moreover, her advocacy for systemic upheaval rooted in critical theory implies a radical ideological position. Thus, as it relates to any universal themes, Spivak argued for systemic upheaval against oppressive conditions, including a forced identity. In that respect, ideological peers of Spivak would be unlikely to follow patriarchal shaving expectations.

Conclusion

The shaving debate is by no means an entirely representative sample of modern feminist discourse. What it does characterize, however, is the flexibility and utility of a provisional feminist compass. Considering its utility, future iterations will be essential in mapping feminist ideology. Though the act of ‘othering’ – of defining oneself against another – is harmful insofar as it dehumanizes, it provides necessary background in political contexts. The second-wave idea that ‘the personal is political’ inextricably tied identity to politics. This model, then, is a first step toward mapping that complex and often undesirable entanglement. Perhaps, over time, one will not need to question whether they are a feminist; if even a misogynist can support feminist ends, identity need not be an end in itself, but can instead be understood in relation to others.

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